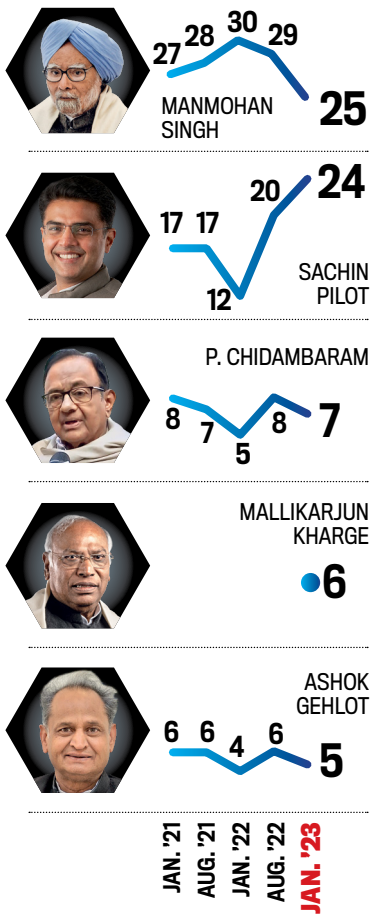
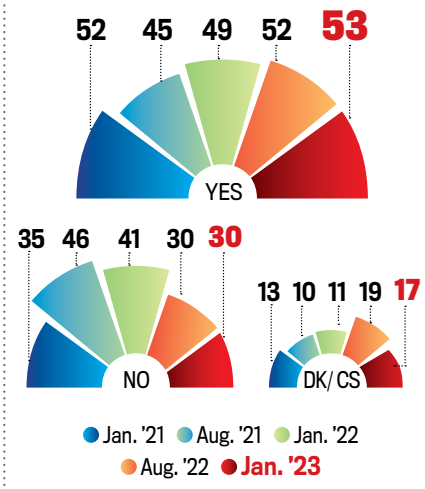
Q WHO IS BEST SUITED AMONG NON-GANDHI LEADERS TO LEAD THE CONGRESS?



Q WILL THE CONGRESS BE BETTER-OFF WITHOUT THE GANDHI FAMILY?



Q IS MALLIKARJUN KHARGE THE RIGHT PERSON TO LEAD THE CONGRESS?



YES	30
NO, Shashi Tharoor would have been better	24
NO, a Gandhi family member should have continued	12
NO, a younger leader should have taken charge	18
DK/ CS	16

All figures in % and rounded off;
DK/ CS: Don't know/ Can't say

top. The party is on the verge of concluding a massive mass outreach programme—the Bharat Jodo Yatra (BJY), an over 3,000 km-long march on foot from Kanyakumari to Kashmir, covering 13 states and one Union territory. Led by Rahul Gandhi, this unique exercise aspires to make Congress, once again, a serious political outfit that can challenge the ruling BJP.

In the past eight years, most critics and even core supporters had given up on a future for the grand old party, not just because of the electoral defeats, but the way it approached electoral politics, crippled by poor preparation, inability to control factional feuds, a top leadership in stasis and, most importantly, a poor reading of the public pulse. Several top leaders, including some close confidants of Rahul, left the party. The large-scale defections resulted in the party losing power in states it had won, be it Madhya Pradesh or Karnataka. And in states like Punjab, Delhi and Meghalaya, it conceded space to emerging forces such as the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) and Trinamool Congress (TMC), which are threatening to usurp the Congress's position as the sole national alternative to the BJP.

While the Yatra has jostled the party out of its organisational sloth, the people are as yet to be convinced of the Congress's ability to cross the final hurdle—at the hustings. Thirty-six per cent of the respondents agree that the Yatra has created a buzz for the party, but they feel the Congress doesn't have the organisational muscle anymore to win elections. Only 29 per cent believe the BJY is a great exercise by the party for mass connect. In fact, there is little improvement in public approval of the party's performance—34 per cent respondents rate the performance of the Congress as outstanding or good, marginally up from 33 per cent in August 22 but still behind the January 2021 ratings when 41 per cent rated Congress performance as outstanding or good. That's the big lesson Congress must take home—the nation is not yet ready to repose faith in the party. To sustain the impetus provided by Rahul's walkathon, Kharge and his team have to make the Congress an election-ready machine.

However, the BJY has certainly